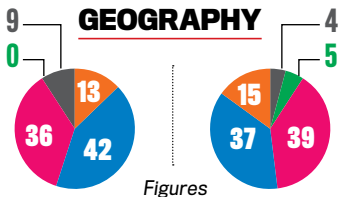
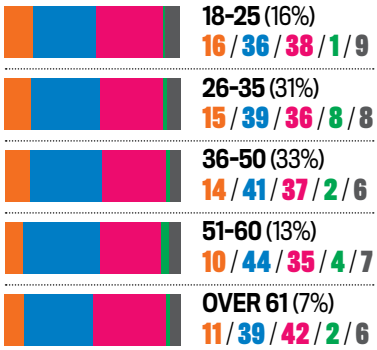
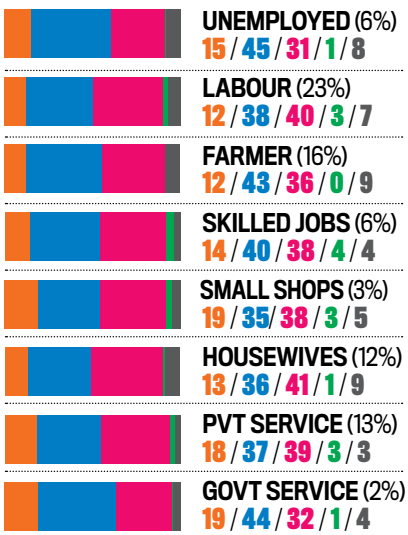
GEOGRAPHY

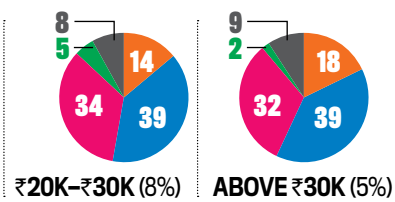


AGE GROUPS



OCCUPATION





Figures in () indicate share in total population; Figures in percentage

to rework strategies," admits BRS working president and KCR's son K.T. Rama Rao. Anti-incumbency had been building up against the party for some time now, yet KCR largely stuck with his incumbent lawmakers. BRS also relied on popular welfare measures, be it the Rythu Bandhu scheme for providing investment support, Rythu Bima scheme offering agricultural insurance to farmers, the Dalit and Backward Class Bandhu schemes for the marginalised or the Gruha Lakshmi scheme to give housing to the poor, to see it through. However, poor implementation of big-ticket programmes like the 2BHK housing and Dalit Bandhu created a new layer of haves and have-nots, angered millions and drove them into the waiting arms of the Congress. For example, there was discontent over Dharani—the Integrated Land Records Management System—a portal that would help land-holders get title deeds through a smooth registration process. However, the system was said to be full of imperfections, and many landowners blamed it for their ownership falling into dispute. The Congress exploited this fear to the hilt by promising to create an efficacious digitisation process.

MANY VOTERS WERE ANTAGONISED BY KCR'S INACCESSIBILITY AND HIS ALLEGEDLY AUTHORITARIAN WAYS. OPPOSITION CHARGES OF NEPOTISM AND CORRUPTION ALSO STUCK TO THE BRS

Many voters were also antagonised by the perceived inaccessibility of KCR and his allegedly authoritarian ways. "Ghamand (arrogance), coupled with the lack of access to KCR and most BRS MLAs alienated voters and led to the rural rout," says Vageeshan. Indeed, the sharp urban-rural divide saw the Congress sweep the countryside, especially in central and south Telangana, through which Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra passed in October-November 2022 and where he returned for electioneering this year.

That said, the Congress surge remained a largely rural phenomenon. Cash-rich Greater Hyderabad did not elect a single Congress candidate from any of its 24 constituencies. BRS picked up 16 seats here, while the All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM) clung on to the seven seats in its Old City bastion for the fourth time. The BJP retained its lone seat of Goshamahal. Analysts say apprehension among a section of voters in Hyderabad that a change of guard may impact development, the business environment and flow of investments may have prompted them to vote for the BRS. The KCR government had laid emphasis on the information technology and pharmaceutical sectors, besides urban infrastructure in and around the city. "But though it helped the BRS win the Greater Hyderabad region, the city-centric model of development contributed to the overall debacle," says E. Venkatesu of the University of Hyderabad.

A VOTE FOR CHANGE

Much of the blame of the BRS defeat lies with KCR himself. Known for his astute poll strategy, the former CM fell into a rut of obduracy this time around—fielding all but a handful of sitting MLAs and announcing the list of candidates as early as August. And this when internal surveys he himself had commissioned revealed that around 35 MLAs were deeply unpopular. Apparently, behind KCR's uncharacteristic inflexibility was a fear of their turning rebels. This made it easier for the Congress to attack the BRS's governance. Ironically, in 11 of the 14 constituencies where it fielded new candidates, the BRS won big.